

THE COMET • FACT DESK SHIFT

The Fact Desk



Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

A note from Deja, the editor of The Comet, the school paper: "You're on the fact desk. Three writers used an AI helper. AI predicts likely words, and it doesn't always check them. So it can be totally wrong and still sound sure. No story gets printed until you check it."

Desk words: **run:** it gets printed **log:** write it down
column: one writer's regular story **stamp:** your verdict box. Pick one.
second source: a place to check that is NOT where you first saw the claim
the ending still stands: it's still true once the facts are fixed

Your method, every draft: Stuck? The Desk Helpers are on p.2.

- **1. UNDERLINE** every checkable claim (names, dates, numbers, places, quotes).
- **2. RANK** — write **C** above claims to CHECK, **S** above SAFE ones.
- **3. LATERAL-READ** — leave the draft. Log a second source that could confirm each C.
- **4. VERDICT** — pick one stamp, give your evidence, and say if the writer's ending still stands.

Typeable PDF? You can't underline, so type your C claims into the table. Skip the S ones.

🔍 DRAFT #1 — PRIYA'S SCIENCE COLUMN, "MOON FACTS"

The Moon is Earth's only natural satellite. Astronauts first landed on the Moon in 1959, and Neil Armstrong was the first person to walk on its surface. By 1972, 12 people had walked on the Moon. On a clear night the Moon seems to shine because it produces its own light — which is why it's the brightest thing in the night sky.

Log your two riskiest claims — the two that would hurt The Comet most if they're wrong.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)		SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D CHECK IT	

☐ RUN — clean, print it	☐ FIX — correct it, then print	☐ KILL — cut the story
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Note to Priya — what's wrong, your second source, and does her ending still stand?

Need a start? What's wrong: _____. I would check _____. The ending still stands / falls because _____.

🔍 DRAFT #2 — THEO'S QUIZ PAGE, "WORLD RECORDS CORNER"

Round 2: Partner A is the partner whose first name comes first in the alphabet. A does Draft #2 on this page. B does Draft #3 on p.3. Pick your stamp and write your note. Then swap sheets and add one claim your partner missed. Swap back and fix your note if you need to.

Same method: underline · mark C or S · log a second source · pick one stamp · write your note.

The Pacific Ocean is the largest ocean on Earth. The Nile River flows north through Egypt and is one of the longest rivers in the world. The tallest mountain above sea level is Mount Everest, which rises in the Andes range in South America. Earth has seven continents, and the largest is Asia. Australia's capital city is Sydney. Put it together and the record-holders sit on three continents: Africa, South America, and Asia.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)		SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D CHECK IT	

☐ RUN — clean, print it	☐ FIX — correct it, then print	☐ KILL — cut the story
---	--	--

Note to Theo — what's wrong, your second source, and does his ending still stand?

Need a start? What's wrong: _____. I would check _____. The ending still stands / falls because _____.

🔍 DESK HELPERS: USE THESE ON EVERY DRAFT

RANK: which claims get a C?

- Dates, names, numbers, places, and quotes. Easy to get wrong, easy to check.
- Words like *first*, *only*, *biggest*, *tallest* — record claims are risky.
- Anything the ending depends on. If it falls, the story falls.
- Mark **S** only when it's low risk: not a record, not a number, and the ending doesn't need it. "Everybody knows it" is not a reason.

Second sources that count

- A textbook or an encyclopedia entry on the topic.
- A museum, space agency, or government website.
- A different website that did not copy the first one.

Does NOT count: asking the same AI again (don't ask the suspect if they're innocent) · the draft itself · "I'd Google it" with no site named.

🔍 DRAFT #3 — MARCUS'S FEATURE, "THE INVENTION ISSUE" _____

Same method: underline · mark C or S · log a second source · pick one stamp · write your note.

Thomas Edison invented the telephone in 1876. As Edison put it, "The telephone is the finest of all my inventions." The next year, in 1877, Edison invented the phonograph — the first machine that could both record and play back sound. A generation later, the Wright brothers made the first successful powered airplane flights in 1903, near Kitty Hawk, North Carolina. Edison's record makes him the most important inventor of the 1800s.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)		SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D CHECK IT	

☐ RUN — clean, print it	☐ FIX — correct it, then print	☐ KILL — cut the story
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Note to Marcus — what's wrong, your second source, and does his ending still stand?

Need a start? What's wrong: _____. I would check _____. The ending still stands / falls because _____.

🔍 EXIT TICKET — LAST CHECK _____

1. In your own words: how can AI sound 100% sure and still be wrong?

2. Name one checkable claim (a name, date, number, place, or quote) you saw or heard this week. Name a second source where you would check it. It can't be the place you first saw or heard it.

Desk rule to keep: smooth is not the same as true. Before you repeat it, post it, or hand it in — check it.